Chapter 6.

MAKING FRIENDS, INFLUENCING PEOPLE

Why India Must Create a Global Constituency

In its quest to become a leading power, India has to successfully navigate the two big contradictions of our times, even while steadily enhancing its comprehensive national power. One is the East–West divide that has been sharpened by the Ukraine conflict. The other is the North–South gap that has been aggravated by Covid, debt, climate change as well as food and energy insecurity. This is on top of the natural compulsion of a rising power to maximize its friends and minimize its problems. India's search for ideal positioning in the global arena may be an unceasing effort. But those with larger ambitions must definitely develop reliable partners and assured sources of support. Their endeavour is also to shape the landscape rather than just operate in it.

The days when India could stir itself episodically while allowing processes to make their own progress are now behind us. Our interests are only expanding with time, and so must our activities and profile. The task before us is to lay the foundations in the *Amrit Kaal* for India to not only be a developed nation but also a leading power. That is why *Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas* (working with all for the progress of all) is as relevant in foreign policy as in the domestic one. After all, diplomacy is all about making friends and influencing people. And the scope for a country that has a natural inclination to treat the world as a family (*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*) is immense in this regard.